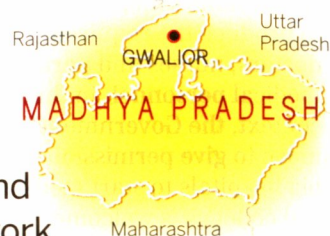


Digital Discipline

An e-governance initiative solves people's problems and even ensures that government employees report for work



RAJIV KUMAR

GOVERNMENT EMPLOYEES
PUNCHING IN FOR WORK

Be it starvation deaths of Saharia primitive tribals or a massacre by dacoits in Bhanwarpura in 2004, headlines from this part of Gwalior district in Madhya Pradesh used to be as gloomy as its arid landscape. But the fruits of e-governance under the Jan Mitra Samadhan Kendra scheme are slowly erasing the painful memories of the region's violent past.

A simple yet effective IT-driven initiative based on a biometric attendance system is bringing effective grassroots governance to villages in Ghatigaon block of Gwalior long abandoned by the Government. In Naugaon village, the once ghostly panchayat building has come alive, thanks to the presence of field-level staff at the cutting edge of the delivery of government services. Says Durbu Adivasi, "In my 60 years, I had never seen government employees attend work here." He was at the panchayat centre to apply for a BPL (below poverty line) ration card. The biometric fingerprint recognition has forced employees to report for work regularly. As a result, Naugaon's school, where teacher absenteeism

was rife, is buzzing with activity. Applicants are given receipts bearing the date by when their work will be done. Data is fed on battery-operated laptops and transferred to the collectorate where delays get flagged electronically and weekly reviews identify the culprits. Launched in September 2009, the scheme has dealt with 17,750 of 18,000 applications within the first six months.

The results are immediately visible. At the weekly Jan Sunwai programme initiated by Shivraj Singh Chouhan, hardly any complaint is received by the Gwalior administration from Ghatigaon block where the scheme has been in force. Given the response, the scheme that provides 72 key rural services of 12 departments was on April 7 extended to all blocks of the district. Meanwhile, the state Government is considering scaling up the initiative to replicate it across the state. Gwalior Collector Akash Tripathi, the brain behind Jan Mitra, saw an earlier such scheme called Gyandoot fail in Dhar, which helped him weed out the glitches. The rural hinterland is beginning to ride the e-highway to the future.

By Ambreesh Mishra